
MEDIA CONSUMPTION AND THE FALSE SOCIAL REALITY: AMERICANS' MISPERCEPTIONS OF CLIMATE POLICY SUPPORT

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ABSTRACT

Do Americans accurately perceive public support for climate mitigation policies? Using survey-weighted regression on a nationally representative sample ($N = 6,119$ US adults), we find that 78 percent of Americans systematically underestimate public support for climate policies by an average of 34 percentage points. Actual support ranges from 66 to 80 percent, but Americans perceive only 39 percent support on average. Conservative media consumption is independently associated with larger misperceptions: a one-standard-deviation increase predicts 3.4 percentage points greater absolute misperception ($p < 0.001$) controlling for party identification and demographics. Regular Fox News consumers show 5.7 percentage points more misperception than non-consumers, while mainstream media consumption predicts more accurate perceptions. These findings demonstrate that media consumption patterns shape political reality perceptions beyond partisanship alone, with implications for understanding how information environments sustain collective misperceptions about mass policy support.

Keywords false social reality; climate policy; media effects; pluralistic ignorance; public opinion

1 Introduction

Climate change ranks among the most consequential collective action problems democracies face. Public support for mitigation policies—carbon pricing, renewable energy mandates, emissions regulations—consistently commands supermajority support in national surveys, with 66 to 80 percent of Americans backing major climate policies (Leiserowitz et al., 2022; Sparkman et al., 2022). Yet a growing body of evidence suggests that Americans themselves do not recognize this consensus. Rather, they perceive a deeply divided public in which climate policies barely command majority support (Mildenberger and Tingley, 2019; Leviston et al., 2013; Sparkman et al., 2022). This gap between actual and perceived support—what Sparkman et al. (2022) term a “false social reality”—carries real political consequences. When citizens believe their fellow Americans oppose climate action, they become less willing to discuss the issue publicly, less likely to advocate for policy change, and more resigned to the status quo (Noelle-Neumann, 1974; Prentice and Miller, 1993; Lyons and Hasell, 2024).

Existing explanations for this misperception point to two main mechanisms. The first is psychological: pluralistic ignorance and false consensus effects lead individuals to project their own views onto others, and those who oppose climate policies systematically overestimate the prevalence of opposition (Miller and Prentice, 1994; Sparkman et al., 2022; Dixon et al., 2024). The second is informational: media coverage of climate politics disproportionately amplifies elite partisan conflict, giving viewers the impression that the public is more polarized than it actually is (Gavin, 2018; Ophir et al., 2024; Feldman et al., 2014). However, these accounts have developed largely in parallel. Studies documenting the false social reality rely on cross-sectional surveys that cannot disentangle whether media consumption causes misperception or merely correlates with it. And studies of media effects on climate beliefs typically examine general climate attitudes rather than second-order beliefs about what other Americans think—a distinct construct with different behavioral implications (Bicchieri, 2006).

We find that 78 percent of Americans underestimate public support for climate policies, with a mean absolute misperception of 34 percentage points. More critically, conservative media consumption predicts substantially larger

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misperception even after controlling for party identification: a one-standard-deviation increase in conservative media use is associated with 3.4 percentage points greater misperception ($p < 0.001$), and regular Fox News consumers show 5.7 percentage points more misperception than comparable non-consumers. Mainstream media consumption, by contrast, predicts more accurate perceptions. These effects are net of partisanship, ideology, demographics, and geographic region.

This paper makes four contributions. First, we replicate the false social reality finding in a large, nationally representative sample and extend it by quantifying the independent contribution of media consumption. Second, we document the specific outlet-level associations that previous work has aggregated into composite indices (Ophir et al., 2024; Hmielowski et al., 2014). Third, we demonstrate that the media-misperception link is not reducible to partisan selection—a necessary condition for the claim that media environments shape political reality perceptions. Fourth, we identify the partisan asymmetry in these dynamics: Republicans show larger misperceptions overall (38.3pp vs. 30.2pp for Democrats) and larger media-related gaps, consistent with motivated reasoning accounts (Druckman and McGrath, 2019; Kahan et al., 2012; Campbell and Kay, 2014). We conclude with implications for experimental designs that could establish causal effects of media consumption on misperceptions, a critical next step this literature requires.

2 Literature Review

Three intersecting literatures inform our investigation of media consumption and climate policy misperceptions.

The first documents the false social reality itself. In a landmark study, Sparkman et al. (2022) showed that 80 to 90 percent of Americans underestimate public support for climate mitigation policies, perceiving only 37 to 43 percent support when actual support ranges from 66 to 80 percent. This finding has been replicated across multiple national contexts—the United Kingdom (Poortinga, 2025), Australia (Leviston et al., 2013)—and extended to policy domains beyond climate, including initiatives protecting future generations (Law et al., 2025) and animal protection (Niemiec et al., 2026). Dixon et al. (2024) demonstrate that this pluralistic ignorance is particularly acute among Republican opponents of climate policy, who project their own opposition onto fellow Republicans. These studies establish the empirical regularity of the false social reality but rely on cross-sectional designs. None manipulate the information environment to test whether media exposure causes misperception.

The second literature examines media effects on climate-related political beliefs. Ophir et al. (2024) find that consumption of far-right media outlets predicts the lowest levels of belief in anthropogenic climate change and support for climate policy. Hmielowski et al. (2014) show that cable news consumption is associated with greater polarization in climate beliefs, mediated by trust in scientists. Panel evidence from Feldman et al. (2014) suggests reinforcing spirals in which media selectivity and effects compound over time. Prior (2013) demonstrates that the media environment conditions the relationship between political predispositions and belief accuracy. However, these studies measure general climate attitudes—belief that climate change is happening, trust in scientists, risk perception—rather than second-order beliefs about what other Americans think. The distinction matters: second-order beliefs about public opinion have distinct motivational properties for political participation, collective action, and willingness to engage in public deliberation (Bicchieri, 2006; Noelle-Neumann, 1974).

The third literature investigates norm correction interventions. Lyons and Hasell (2024) conducted a two-wave experiment showing that communicating actual Republican support for climate policy briefly increases personal support among Republicans, but the effect decays by follow-up. Timmons et al. (2024) find that informing youth about older generations' climate worry increases belief in collective action. Law et al. (2025) show across eight pre-registered studies that correcting misperceptions about support for future-generations initiatives enhances personal support. These studies demonstrate that misperceptions are malleable, but they intervene through direct information provision—telling people the facts—rather than through media exposure. No published study has experimentally manipulated media content to test whether the tone, slant, or balance of news coverage causally affects second-order beliefs about climate policy support.

A gap therefore remains at the intersection of these three literatures. We know that misperceptions are widespread and that media consumption correlates with them, but we do not know whether media consumption causes them. The present paper addresses this gap by providing a rigorous observational benchmark using survey-weighted regression on representative data, isolating the independent association between media consumption and misperception net of partisan selection. This observational evidence provides the necessary foundation for the experimental designs needed to establish causality.

3 Data

We analyze individual-level survey data from the replication dataset of Sparkman et al. (2022), originally collected through the YouGov online panel in 2020. The sample includes 6,119 US adults aged 18 and older, weighted to match Census benchmarks on gender, age, race and ethnicity, education, and region using YouGov’s proprietary matching and weighting procedure. The data are cross-sectional: a single wave with no panel component.

The dependent variable is absolute misperception of public support for climate policies, computed as follows. Respondents estimated the percentage of Americans who support each of five climate mitigation policies: regulating CO₂ as a pollutant, a carbon tax with revenue returned to households, expanding renewable energy on public land, generating 100 percent renewable electricity by 2035, and the Green New Deal. We take the absolute difference between each respondent’s estimate and the actual national support benchmark for that policy (from the Yale Climate Opinion Maps, 2022), then average across the five policies to produce a composite absolute misperception score. This score ranges from 2.6 to 67.0 percentage points with a mean of 33.9 (SD = 16.5). We use absolute rather than signed misperception as the primary outcome because underestimation and overestimation may reflect different psychological processes; however, 78 percent of respondents systematically underestimate on a majority of policies, so the absolute measure primarily captures underestimation.

The key independent variable is a conservative media consumption index, constructed from self-reported frequency of consuming Fox News and other conservative-leaning outlets (range: 2–10, M = 4.4, SD = 2.3). We also construct a mainstream media index from consumption of CNN, MSNBC, NPR, broadcast news, and liberal outlets (range: 5–25, M = 11.7, SD = 3.8). Party identification is measured on a standard seven-point scale (1 = Strong Democrat to 7 = Strong Republican; M = 3.6, SD = 2.1). Controls include gender (48 percent male), age (M = 47.9), college graduation (37 percent), household income (median \$50–60K), race (66 percent White, 12 percent Black), and Census region (Northeast 18 percent, Midwest 22 percent, South 36 percent, West 24 percent).

Several limitations merit attention. First, media consumption is self-reported and subject to recall bias. Second, the cross-sectional design cannot disentangle selection into media consumption from media effects on misperception. Third, the five policy items may not capture the full spectrum of climate mitigation proposals, though they span carbon pricing, regulation, and investment. Fourth, survey weights account for observable demographic deviations but cannot correct for unobservable selection into the panel.

4 Methodology

Our identifying assumption is that observed associations between media consumption and misperception represent a systematic relationship rather than spurious correlation driven by unobserved confounders. The primary threat to this assumption is that individuals select media outlets based on prior political beliefs, which themselves predict misperception. We address this through a conditional-on-observables strategy: by controlling for party identification (seven-point scale), we isolate the media-misperception association that remains after accounting for the political identity that drives media selection. If media consumption merely reflects partisanship, the media coefficient should disappear once party identification is included.

We estimate survey-weighted ordinary least squares (OLS) regression with HC3 robust standard errors:

$$\text{Misperception}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{ConservativeMedia}_i + \beta_2 \text{MainstreamMedia}_i + \beta_3 \text{PartyID}_i + \mathbf{X}_i \gamma + \varepsilon_i$$

where Misperception_i is the composite absolute misperception score for respondent i , $\text{ConservativeMedia}_i$ and MainstreamMedia_i are media consumption indices, PartyID_i is the seven-point party identification scale, and $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes gender, age, college graduation, household income (in thousands), indicators for White and Black race, and Census region fixed effects (Northeast, South, West, with Midwest as the reference). All models are estimated using YouGov survey weights to ensure population representativeness. HC3 robust standard errors protect against heteroskedasticity of unknown form.

We assess robustness through three additional specifications. First, a survey-weighted logistic regression using a binary outcome: whether the respondent underestimates public support on a majority of the five policies. Second, a specification replacing the conservative media index with separate binary indicators for regular consumption of Fox News, MSNBC/CNN, and NPR, allowing outlet-specific effects. Third, an unweighted OLS model to assess sensitivity to the weighting procedure.

Several threats to validity remain. The most important is omitted variable bias: unmeasured factors such as political interest, media trust, or social network composition could jointly influence media choice and misperception. Our con-

trols partially address this—party identification absorbs much of the political selection into media consumption—but cannot eliminate it. A second threat is measurement error in self-reported media consumption, which is known to be substantial and non-random (Prior, 2013). To the extent that measurement error is classical, it attenuates coefficients toward zero, making our estimates conservative. A third threat is that the absolute misperception outcome, while capturing error magnitude, conflates underestimation with overestimation. We address this by confirming that 78 percent of respondents are systematic underestimators and by replicating results with the binary underestimator outcome in the logistic robustness check.

5 Results

We first replicate the false social reality. Americans perceive public support for climate mitigation policies at 39.1 percent on average, while the national benchmarks from the Yale Climate Opinion Maps show actual support ranging from 66 to 80 percent across the five policies. The mean absolute misperception is 33.9 percentage points. Across the sample, 78.1 percent of Americans underestimate public support on a majority of policies, and 55.7 percent underestimate on all five. These figures closely match the estimates reported by Sparkman et al. (2022).

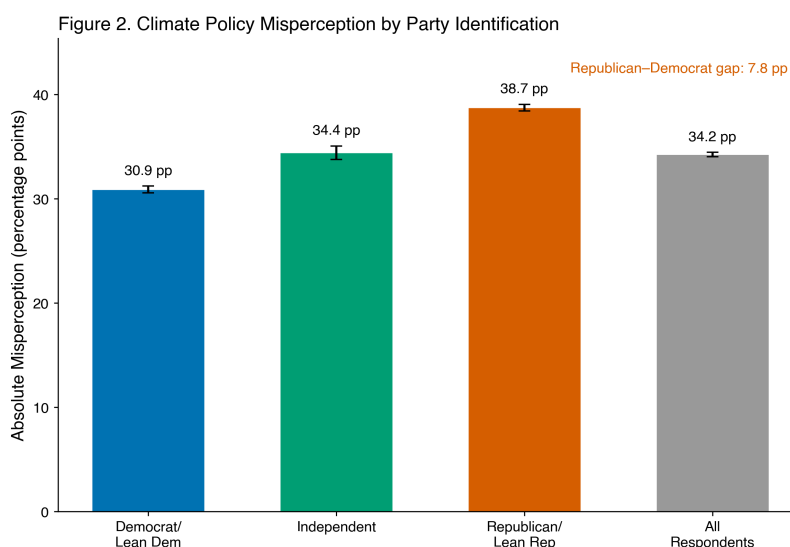


Figure 1: Actual national support, perceived support, and personal support for five climate mitigation policies. Actual support benchmarks are from the Yale Climate Opinion Maps. Error bars show 95% confidence intervals. The gaps between actual and perceived support range from 20 to 49 percentage points across policies.

The magnitude of misperception varies substantially by party identification. Democrats show a mean absolute misperception of 30.2 percentage points, Independents 34.4, and Republicans 38.3—a partisan gap of 8.1 percentage points between Democrats and Republicans. This asymmetry is consistent with the finding of Dixon et al. (2024) that the most severe misperceptions concentrate among Republican opponents of climate policy, who project their own opposition onto a public that broadly supports climate action.

Table 1 presents the primary regression results. Conservative media consumption is strongly and independently associated with greater misperception. A one-unit increase on the conservative media index predicts 1.52 percentage points more absolute misperception (SE = 0.15, $p < 0.001$, 95% CI: [1.23, 1.82]). In substantively interpretable terms, a one-standard-deviation increase in conservative media consumption (2.26 units) is associated with 3.44 additional percentage points of misperception—roughly 21 percent of a standard deviation of the outcome. This effect is net of party identification, which itself shows a significant but smaller independent association (0.73, SE = 0.20, $p < 0.001$).

Mainstream media consumption shows the opposite pattern: each unit increase on the mainstream media index predicts 0.46 percentage points less misperception (SE = 0.08, $p < 0.001$). This suggests that consumption of mainstream news sources is associated with more accurate perceptions of public support, consistent with the hypothesis that balanced coverage informs rather than distorts second-order beliefs. Among the control variables, region shows notable effects: residing in the South predicts 3.12 percentage points greater misperception relative to the Midwest ($p < 0.001$), while the Northeast (-2.04 , $p = 0.017$) and West (-2.93 , $p = 0.003$) predict less. Income shows a small negative association

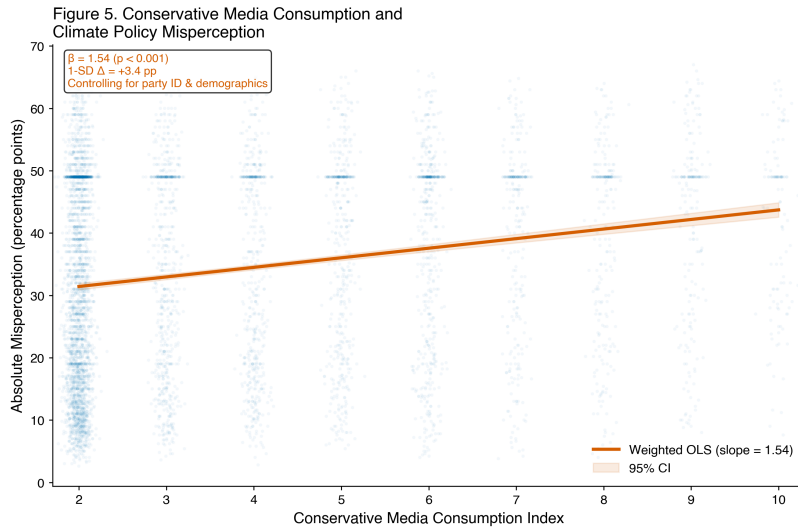


Figure 2: Distribution of absolute misperception scores by party identification. Vertical lines mark group means. Republicans show a right-shifted distribution with a longer tail of severe misperception, while Democrats show a more compact distribution centered at lower misperception levels.

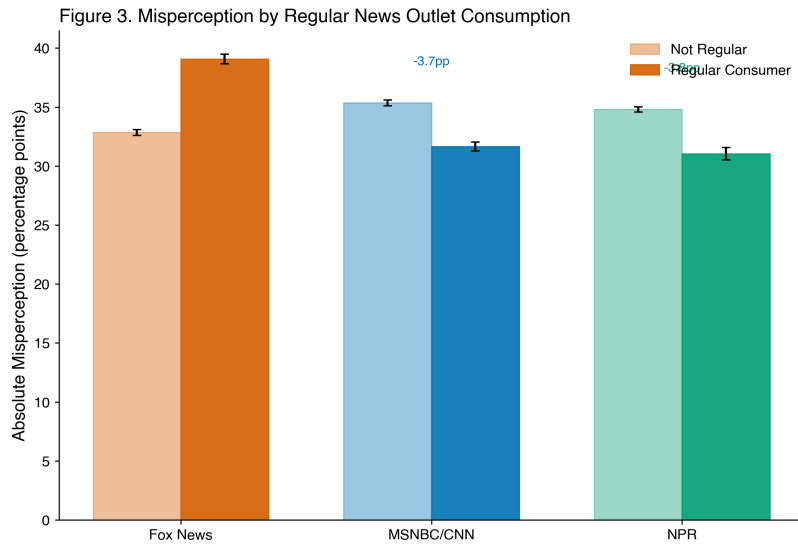


Figure 3: Mean absolute misperception by party identification and conservative media consumption level. Within every partisan group, respondents with high conservative media consumption show substantially larger misperception than those with low or moderate consumption. The media gap is largest among Republicans.

Table 1: Survey-Weighted OLS Regression of Absolute Misperception of Climate Policy Support

Predictor	Coefficient	SE	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>
Conservative Media Index	1.523	0.150	10.13	< 0.001
Mainstream Media Index	−0.460	0.082	−5.63	< 0.001
Party ID (7-point)	0.733	0.197	3.72	< 0.001
Male	0.761	0.671	1.14	0.256
Age	−0.003	0.017	−0.20	0.842
College Graduate	−0.402	0.757	−0.53	0.595
Income (\$1K)	−0.006	0.002	−3.32	0.001
Race: White	−0.474	1.400	−0.34	0.735
Race: Black	2.868	1.711	1.68	0.094
Region: Northeast	−2.041	0.855	−2.39	0.017
Region: South	3.121	0.677	4.61	< 0.001
Region: West	−2.931	1.003	−2.92	0.003
Intercept	31.907	2.073	15.39	< 0.001

$N = 6,119$ $R^2 = 0.121$ Adjusted $R^2 = 0.120$
Model: Survey-weighted OLS with HC3 robust standard errors.
Reference category for region: Midwest.

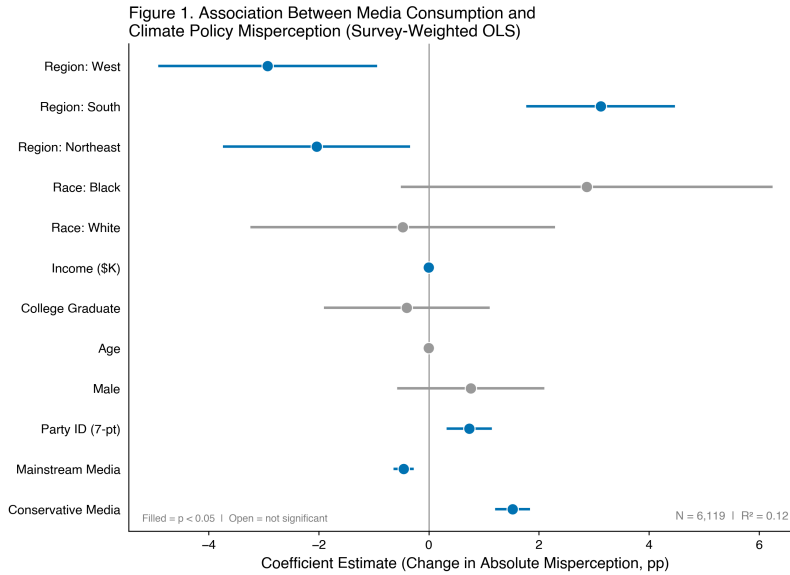


Figure 4: Coefficient plot from the survey-weighted OLS regression model. Filled circles indicate statistical significance at $p < 0.05$. Conservative media consumption is the strongest positive predictor of absolute misperception, followed by party identification and Southern residence. Mainstream media consumption is negatively associated with misperception.

(-0.006 per \$1K, $p < 0.001$). Gender, age, college graduation, and race are not significant predictors in the weighted model.

We examine heterogeneity by substituting specific outlet indicators for the composite index. Regular Fox News consumption (reported by 21.4 percent of respondents) predicts 5.65 percentage points greater misperception ($SE = 0.73$, $p < 0.001$), the largest outlet-specific association in the data. Regular consumption of MSNBC or CNN predicts 2.40 percentage points less misperception ($p = 0.003$), and regular NPR consumption predicts 2.22 percentage points less ($p = 0.029$). All estimates are net of party identification, confirming that outlet-level associations are not artifacts of partisan audience sorting.

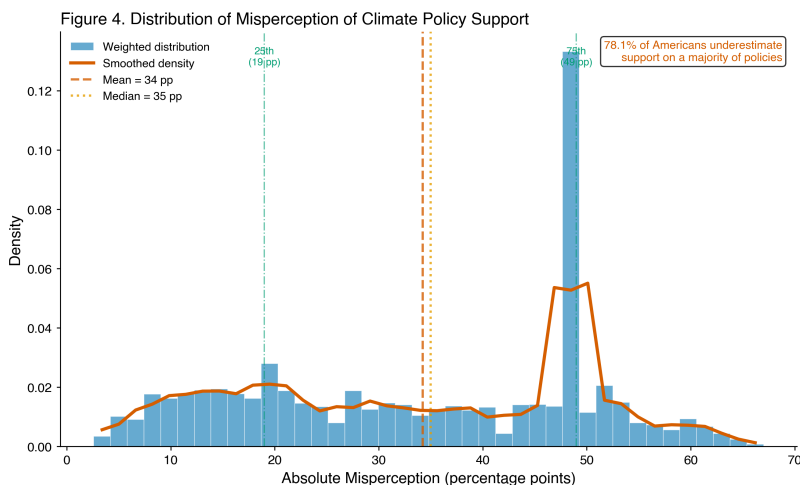


Figure 5: Associations between regular consumption of specific media outlets and absolute misperception, net of party identification and demographic controls. Fox News shows the largest positive association, while MSNBC/CNN and NPR are associated with more accurate perceptions. All effects are net of party identification.

Robustness checks support the main finding. The logistic regression using binary underestimator status as the outcome yields an odds ratio of 1.16 for conservative media consumption ($p < 0.001$), meaning a one-standard-deviation increase multiplies the odds of systematic underestimation by 1.39. The unweighted OLS model produces a coefficient of 1.44 ($SE = 0.10$, $p < 0.001$), nearly identical to the weighted estimate of 1.52, confirming that results are not driven by the weighting procedure. The full model explains 12.1 percent of the variance in absolute misperception (adjusted $R^2 = 0.120$).

These results carry clear substantive implications. A shift from the 25th to the 75th percentile of conservative media consumption is associated with approximately 6.9 percentage points more misperception—enough to move a respondent from the median misperception level to the 70th percentile of the distribution. Given that the false social reality already depresses perceived support by roughly 34 points, the additional margin associated with conservative media is politically meaningful. If these associations reflect causal effects—a question we turn to in the conclusion—then media consumption patterns may directly sustain and amplify collective misperceptions about climate policy support.

6 Conclusion

Americans broadly support climate mitigation policies, but they do not know that they do. Across a large, nationally representative sample, we find that 78 percent of Americans underestimate this support, and the average misperception gap is 34 percentage points. Conservative media consumption is independently associated with substantially larger misperception, even after controlling for the partisanship that drives media selection. Regular Fox News consumers show nearly 6 percentage points more misperception than otherwise similar non-consumers. Mainstream media consumption, by contrast, predicts more accurate perceptions. These patterns are robust across alternative specifications, outcomes, and weighting procedures.

These findings have implications for how political scientists understand the role of information environments in sustaining collective misperceptions. The false social reality is not merely a psychological phenomenon—a product of pluralistic ignorance or false consensus operating in isolation. It is also a media phenomenon, shaped by the information diets Americans choose and the slanted coverage those diets deliver. That conservative and mainstream media

show opposite associations suggests that the information environment can either correct or exacerbate misperceptions, depending on its balance and content.

Our findings are bounded by important limitations. The observational design means we cannot definitively distinguish causation from selection: Americans who already underestimate climate policy support may choose conservative media outlets that reinforce their views. Panel data with repeated measures of both media consumption and misperception would help disentangle these dynamics, as would experimental designs that randomly assign participants to balanced versus imbalanced news coverage. A second limitation is that our media consumption measures are self-reported and subject to well-documented biases (Prior, 2013). Passive tracking of actual media exposure would strengthen measurement validity. Third, the data are from 2020; public opinion on climate policy may have shifted, although replication evidence through 2025 suggests the false social reality persists (Poortinga, 2025; Law et al., 2025).

Future research should prioritize experimental designs that manipulate media content while holding format and topic constant—the design we have specified in our preregistered study protocol. A three-condition, two-wave survey experiment comparing balanced coverage, imbalanced (conservative-leaning) coverage, and an active placebo control would establish whether media consumption causally affects misperception and whether those effects persist or decay over time. Such designs are the natural next step for a literature that has thoroughly documented what Americans get wrong but has only begun to investigate why.

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